

Islamic Extremism and Bangsamoro Transition

Philippines, Mindanao

SIGNAL

The first elected Bangsamoro parliament is a hung house where the rival BFP and UBJP camps – both heirs of a fractured MILF – must build a coalition to elect a Chief Minister by October 30, shifting the near-term story from BTA extension to an unprecedentedly competitive, Manila-enmeshed contest over BARMM governance.

FRACTURE

The MILF's political-and-military unity has formally ruptured, with the movement's erstwhile armed-wing chief and 40 senior commanders severed from the organization while the factions now compete for control of the region's government, turning former comrades into electoral adversaries whose rivalry could be exploited by national political forces.

The 41-seat coalition requirement will force a BFP-led governing majority with Macacua as elected Chief Minister, producing a politically fractured parliament whose gridlock and Manila patronage ties reduce the MILF's institutional autonomy over the peace and normalization agenda by March 2027.

70%

PROBABILITY

TARGET: MARCH 2027

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

WHAT'S NEW

- **First BARMM parliamentary election (Sept 14) produces hung parliament:** The 80-seat result stands at BFP 31, UBJP 24, BGC 8, SIAP 6, other parties 7, sectoral 8 – no bloc near the 41 seats needed to elect a Chief Minister. Turnout reached 84.34%, exceeding COMELEC's 70-75% target.
- **Coalition scramble underway with BGC as kingmaker:** Macacua has publicly declared coalition "unavoidable"; both BFP and UBJP are in negotiations, with the 8-seat BARMM Grand Coalition of entrenched political clans holding the decisive swing vote ahead of the October 30 inaugural session.
- **MILF-BFP split finalized:** The MILF Central Committee stripped Macacua of his BIAF Chief of Staff post along with 40+ senior commanders in a Sept 3 general assembly, 11 days before the polls. Macacua's Aug 15 ambush (which COMELEC classified as election-related) and his subsequent win in Maguindanao del Norte 3rd District formalize the rupture.

- **Chief Minister race draws national proxy dynamics:** Rappler analysis frames the contest as a potential Marcos-Duterte 2028 proxy war – Macacua is Marcos-aligned (appointed interim CM in March 2025 over MILF objections), while the MILF backed Leni Robredo in 2022, potentially importing the national rivalry into BARMM's first elected government.
- **Kuala Lumpur peace talks (Sept 25) produce transition roadmap:** GPH-MILF panels agreed on a post-election transition roadmap, extending ceasefire mechanisms (AHJAG to 2027, CPC to 2028), adopting a Small Arms and Light Weapons management framework, and establishing a technical working group for CAB implementation. 13,855 combatants and 2,575 weapons remain to be processed.
- **Jihadist threat at historic low but MILF fracture creates new risks:** ASG declared "inactive" (JAPIC, April 2026), ISEAP province status downgraded, attacks near zero. However, Crisis Group #358 documents 27,000+ unregistered firearms in BARMM and warns that rival blocs may enlist armed groups – including ASG and BIFF remnants – as tools of political coercion.
- **Probability change explanation:** Down from 75% to 70%. The previous prediction (BTA extension under Manila-dictated terms) was directionally correct – Marcos had already installed Macacua as interim CM in March 2025 – but the mechanism has shifted from legislative extension to coalition arithmetic. The new 70% reflects confidence that Manila's leverage persists through Macacua's 31-seat bloc but tempered by genuine uncertainty over coalition outcomes and how much of the normalization track advances amid partisan gridlock.

ANALYSIS

POLITICAL

The Sept 14 election structurally ended the transitional era and opened a coalition-formation scramble as much about national politics as Bangsamoro governance. Neither MILF-descended party can govern alone: Macacua's BFP took 31 seats, Murad Ebrahim's UBJP 24, leaving the 8-seat BGC of entrenched political clans as the decisive kingmaker (COMELEC official proclamation). Macacua – appointed interim Chief Minister by Marcos in March 2025 over MILF objections, stripped of BIAF command alongside 40+ commanders in early September – is Marcos-aligned and explicitly backed the President in 2022, while the MILF backed Leni Robredo. A BFP-led government would extend Malacañang's control over the BARMM executive.

Rappler's analysis flags that the Duterte camp has incentive to back Murad/UBJP against the Marcos-tied Macacua, potentially importing the 2028 national rivalry into the region's first elected parliament. MILF First Vice Chair Iqbal previously called the Macacua installation a "regime change" outside the CAB's bilateral channels, meaning a Macacua chief ministry would consolidate a Manila-sanctioned successor leadership that the MILF's formal organs have repudiated. The practical stakes are immediate – the new

parliament convenes October 30 and must inherit unfinished legislative business including the Bangsamoro Revenue Code, which sat deferred in the BTA.

ECONOMIC

The economic lever runs through the ₱114-billion BARMM budget and the deeply unfinished socioeconomic side of normalization. BARMM is overwhelmingly dependent on the national annual block grant, so whichever coalition governs still relies on Malacañang's budget releases. The decommissioning dispute is now data-rich on both sides: the government counters MILF's charge that "not a single one has successfully transitioned to productive civilian life" by citing ₱100,000 cash assistance per decommissioned fighter (26,000+ processed) and ₱4 billion+ in programs since 2019, while admitting ₱788 million earmarked for final decommissioning was returned to the Treasury because of MILF postponements.

Roughly 13,855 combatants and 2,575 weapons remain to be processed. OPAPRU's pivot to a Colombia-style monthly stipend for decommissioned combatants (mostly aged 50-65, for whom vocational training is impractical) signals Manila is reaching for new financial instruments because one-off lump sums have not produced durable civilian livelihoods. The World Bank-managed Bangsamoro Normalization Trust Fund and EU/Japan/Australia camp-transformation projects (₱4 billion in roads, health, water, solar) remain the structural economic antidote to re-radicalization, but their delivery now depends on a coalition government with no built-in majority, raising the risk that socioeconomic delivery slows further amid coalition bargaining.

MILITARY

The security picture is bifurcated: the state-vs-jihadist threat is at a historic low even as the MILF's internal fracture and firearms proliferation pose the sharper near-term risk. Crisis Group Report #358 ("Policing the Bangsamoro," Sept 3) documents that clan feuds (rido), political rivalries, and criminal networks now pose a greater threat than state-militant fighting; the region holds an estimated 27,000+ unregistered firearms; and the PNP remains weak and politicized such that the military still carries the burden of public order.

ASG has been declared an "inactive group" (JAPIC, April 2026) with membership collapsed from 130 (2021) to ~50. ISEAP lost its "province" designation (Oct 2024-Jan 2026) with attacks near zero and central ISIS funding ceased since 2022 (MEMRI). However, the same assessments flag DIMG remnants recruiting discreetly, two Tajik nationals sighted with DIMG in April 2026, and foreign-fighter transit persisting through BARMM's ungoverned spaces.

The acute risk is the MILF split itself: the Macacua ambush (Aug 15) demonstrated that intra-MILF rivalries have acquired an armed dimension. Crisis Group and other analysts warn that rival blocs and clan elites may enlist armed groups – including ASG and BIFF remnants that AFP-WestMinCom explicitly flagged as exploitable "tools for coercion" during the election – to intimidate or disrupt the coalition process. The AHJAG and CPC ceasefire-mechanism extensions (to 2027 and 2028) and the SALW management framework agreed at the Sept 25 Kuala Lumpur talks are the formal instruments meant to contain this

spillover, but they depend on a functioning civilian government that has yet to be formed.

| TECHNOLOGICAL

Technology's role is concentrated in electoral integrity and firearms control rather than kinetic counterterrorism. The pre-shaded-ballot discovery in 36 Maluso, Basilan precincts – which forced COMELEC to replace ballots and extend voting – and the 800+ teacher withdrawals from election duties point to systemic procedural vulnerabilities in the region's first automated parliamentary exercise, though 84.34% turnout and 108 IRI international observers provided compensating transparency.

On the security-technology front, the proposed GPH-MILF Framework for Small Arms and Light Weapons Management (SALW-M) is the most concrete technological-policy deliverable: it channels decommissioning, private-armed-group disbandment, and firearms reduction into a codified program routed through the Joint Normalization Committee, with ceasefire mechanisms renewed in the same Sept 25 Kuala Lumpur package. Notably absent is any evidence of meaningful state investment in community-level P/CVE surveillance or monitoring technology. The Bangsamoro Revenue Code bill – a fiscal-institutional technology for self-governance – sat deferred in the BTA and now awaits a coalition parliament, making the region's financial apparatus itself hostage to political deadlock.

WATCH INDICATORS

- Which party's candidate is elected Chief Minister at the Oct 30 inaugural session and the size/makeup of the winning 41+ coalition
- Whether the BGC (8 seats) and smaller parties/sectoral representatives align with BFP or UBJP
- Whether new armed incidents or election-dispute rulings target Macacua, Murad, or their allies during coalition negotiations
- Progress (or further deferral) of the Bangsamoro Revenue Code and other inherited BTA legislation in the new parliament
- Whether MILF central organs or Murad's faction formally contest or legitimize a Macacua chief ministry
- Any sign of national-level (Malacañang or Duterte camp) interference in coalition bargaining
- Renewed decommissioning milestones or the Colombia-style stipend moving from proposal to funded policy

PROBABILITY TRIGGERS

EVENT	DIRECTION
Macacua/BFP secures the 41-seat majority and is elected Chief Minister on Oct 30	Up
BGC or a sizable bloc defects to Murad/UBJP, blocking a Macacua chief ministry	Down
MILF formally ratifies the exclusion of Macacua and initiates a rival/factional armed mobilization	Up
A renewed decommissioning schedule or funded stipend scheme clears trust deficit and unblocks normalization	Down
A serious armed incident (ambush/clash) strikes a party leader during coalition talks, signaling violence replaces bargaining	Up
Malacañang budget holdbacks or block-grant disruptions pressure the incoming parliament into Manila-friendly concessions	Up

KEY SOURCES

1. Race for BARMM's top post could turn into Marcos-Duterte proxy war – Rappler (Sep 2026)
2. A different kind of negotiation: building a coalition government – MindaNews (Sep 2026)
3. Govt, MILF agree to advance smooth BARMM transition – Manila Times (Sep 26, 2026)
4. KL breakthrough: Bangsamoro peace process back on track – Inquirer (Sep 2026)
5. Policing the Bangsamoro: Peace in the Southern Philippines – International Crisis Group #358 (Sep 3, 2026)
6. Bangsamoro Peace Process Hits Snag Amid Political Tensions – International Affairs Forum (Sep 2026)
7. Philippines Terrorism Outlook 25 Years After 9/11 – Eurasia Review (Sep 2026)
8. Bangsamoro poll results trigger coalition talks – Manila Times (Sep 21, 2026)
9. IRI Preliminary Findings: Philippines' 2026 Bangsamoro Parliamentary Elections – IRI (Sep 14-15, 2026)
10. ISIS East Asia Loses Status As Province – MEMRI JTTM (2026)
11. BARMM's first elected parliament proclaimed, to assume office Oct. 30 – BARMM Official (Sep 16, 2026)

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